

LIFE'S BIGGEST ISSUE

March 20, 2022

TEXT: Matthew 6 33 *“Seek first His kingdom and His righteousness, and all these things will be given to you.”*

INTRO: We could talk about many issues today:

- Sex...
- Marriage...
- Raising children...
- Career paths...
- Retirement...
- Religion...
- Politics...
- Health...

All of the issues I just mentioned, we all have in common, and how we deal with each of them is vitally important to our way of life and what we will be able to accomplish in this earth. It would

be interesting to see what priority each person in the room would give to each of these issues.

I can assure you, as important as each of these issues are, there is an issue that each of us grapple with on a daily basis that trumps all the others because of how big a part it plays in each of our lives. That issue is money! I would guess that money is the biggest issue each of us face:

- How we get it...
- What we do with it...
- How we go about managing it...
- Whether we work for it or we allow it to work for us...
- Whether it is the object of our love, or we see it as a tool to accomplish our “WHY”...

There are probably people here today that would take exception with me calling money “Life’s *Biggest Issue*” but the Bible itself mentions money and possessions more than 2,000 times! Money and possessions are mentioned more than many other subjects:

- Love is mentioned 310 times...
- Faith is mentioned 336 times...
- Sin is mentioned 415 times...
- Worship is mentioned 503 times...
- Forgiveness is mentioned 50 times...

Why is it that money and possessions get more screen play in the Bible than almost any other subject? I believe it is because it is the one thing that every human being must grapple with every single day of their lives.

CAN THINGS BRING SATISFACTION TO THE HUMAN EXPERIENCE?

The old adage says, “*Money can’t buy happiness.*” Someone said, “*They must not know where to shop.*” The statement “*Money can’t buy happiness*” Points to the fact that happiness is derived from within rather than coming from external sources.

I say, *“Peace and happiness come from a vertical relationship rather than horizontal things.”*

How we handle money says a lot about our:

- Morality...
- Spirituality...
- Character...

The problem we face when dealing with money is that we are often tempted to seek earthly things rather than kingdom things. When we seek earthly things:

- They never satisfy...
- They leave us unfulfilled...
- They are unsustainable...

1 Timothy 6:6-11 (NKJV) ***“Godliness with contentment is great gain. ⁷ For we brought nothing into the world, and we can take nothing out of it. ⁸ But if we have food and clothing, we will be content with that. ⁹ Those who want to get rich fall into temptation and a***

trap and into many foolish and harmful desires that plunge people into ruin and destruction.

¹⁰ For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil. Some people, eager for money, have wandered from the faith and pierced themselves with many griefs. ¹¹ But you, man of God, flee from all this, and pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance, and gentleness.” This passage points out the following:

- If we seek Godliness, we get contentment...
- We came into the world emptyhanded and we will leave emptyhanded...
- The craving for riches is a trap of the enemy... (Source – Motili) America has a 90% share of the worlds self-storage market
 - The industry is growing 8% year over year
 - In 2019 the industry was valued at almost \$40 Billion dollars – 2019 Self-Storage Almanac says there were more than 60,000 self-storage facilities in America – 1 in 11 Americans have a self-storage unit and average paying more than \$90 per month for

their unit – Americans possess all these things, yet we are one of the most unhappy, dissatisfied nations on the earth – We still grapple with depression and suicide at an alarming rate – Time Magazine say's 16 million Americans take anti-depressants daily at a cost of \$17 billion annually, resulting in a \$210 billion dollar loss in productivity and additional health care costs)

- Earthly riches bring about ruin, destruction and sorrow...
- Money is not evil – The love of money is evil... (I know more people who do not have money but love it than I know people who have it and love it)

CONCLUSION:

It is true that things are needed for the human experience:

- We NEED food...
- We NEED shelter...
- We NEED clothing...

- We NEED relationships... (With God and man)

The truth is, we WANT things, but we don't NEED them! The pursuit of this world goods brings about one result – discontent. ***“Tear down my barns and build bigger barns.”***

“Seeking first the kingdom” produces a completely different result – contentment.

The result is dependent on the pursuit. What are we pursuing?

LIFE'S BIGGEST ISSUE

March 27, 2022

TEXT: Matthew 6 33 *“Seek first His kingdom and His righteousness, and all these things will be given to you.”*

INTRO: Last week we talked about whether *“Things”* could bring happiness to the human experience. the Bible itself mentions money and possessions more than 2,000 times! Money and possessions are mentioned more than most other subjects:

- Love is mentioned 310 times...
- Faith is mentioned 336 times...
- Sin is mentioned 415 times...
- Worship is mentioned 503 times...
- Forgiveness is mentioned 50 times...

Why is it that money and possessions get more screen play in the Bible than almost any other subject? I believe it is because it is the one thing

that every human being must grapple with every single day of their lives.

Money is actually a test. We are tested on:

- How we get it...
- What we do with it...
- How we go about managing it...
- Whether we work for it or we allow it to work for us...
- Whether it is the object of our love, or we see it as a tool to accomplish our “WHY”...

Today I want to ask and answer four questions:

- What is the proper approach for a believer to take toward things?
- How are we to know what to give?
- If we are citizens of the Kingdom, why do we experience lack?
- What should the expectation of the generous be?

WHAT IS THE PROPER APPROACH FOR A BELIEVER TO TAKE TOWARD THINGS?

We are Kingdom people. Kingdom people contribute toward the vision of the Kingdom, which allows them the opportunity to invest in something that is bigger and much more fruitful than they are, in and of themselves. There is a minimum investment required called the tithe. Malachi 3 *“Bring all the tithe into the storehouse that there may be resources at my house.”*

- Tithe = 10%
- 10% of what? Everything
- Net vs. gross
- Generosity vs. compliance

In essence, everything in the Kingdom already belongs to the King. Many people believe the 10% belongs to the Lord, but the truth is, 100% belongs to Him. Giving on our part is simply the King allowing His resources to pass through our

hands, which becomes a test of whether He can trust us with resources.

The pastor or the church does not establish the percentage of giving required for Kingdom citizens – The King does! (My running joke with Miguel Moreno)

If one has an issue with tithing or giving, their issue is not with the pastor or the church, their issue is with the King of the Kingdom! So, if you are uncomfortable with me talking about this subject, you cannot resolve the issue by going to a church that doesn't talk about it, you must resolve it with the King of the Kingdom which you have chosen to be in. (Guy in Malvern who quit the church because I talked too much about giving)

God Himself is a giver. ***“For God so loved the world that He gave...”*** While God is a giver, He ALWAYS reserves a portion for Himself. This has been true from the beginning! Genesis

2:16-17 *“Every tree in the garden is yours to eat from, BUT don’t touch the tree of knowledge of good and evil.”* He is saying, *“Do not eat of that tree, it is mine!”* This is properly termed in theological circles as *“The law of divine portion.”*

HOW ARE WE TO KNOW WHAT TO GIVE?

A good rule of thumb:

- 10% to the King...
- 10% to savings...
- 33% to Uncle Sam...
- 47% to live on and support Kingdom Projects...

God gives two kinds of seed:

- Sowing seed... (Investing)
- Eating seed... (Consumer)

We should never be guilty of eating His portion because He always reserves a portion for

Himself – Someone said, *“Don’t sow you’re eating seed, and don’t eat your sowing seed.”*

In the secular world this is called, *The law of cause and effect.*” In Kingdom culture we call it, *“The law of sowing and reaping.”* Robert Louis Stevenson said, *“Sooner or later everyone sits down to a banquet of circumstance.”* Oh, how true this statement is!

There are too many broke, busted and disgusted Kingdom citizens living in poverty. What is the definition of poverty? Not having enough to provide for the necessities of life – But it is far more than that – It is not having enough to accomplish our “WHY”!

What would you do if funds were not a problem? Do it Bro you are a KINGS KID!

**IF WE ARE CITIZENS OF THE
KINGDOM WHY DO WE EXPERIENCE
LACK?**

The most common causes of a poverty mentality in the Kingdom are:

- Lack of faith... (Can't believe what God said in His Word)
- Lack of trust... (Can't turn loose of what I have in our hands because we are not sure the King will give us what is in His hand – Illustrate this – Giving is a trust issue)
- Speaking the wrong things... (I'm broke – I'm poor – Nothing good ever happens to me – That is just my luck – We are saving up for a rainy day) (Deacon who said, *“You never know when we might have to put a roof on this building.”* – Guess what? We had to put a roof on a two-year-old building, and the shingle company had gone out of business – No warranty)

Lean over and tell negative Nancy, *“Shut up!”*
Let's say this together - ***“Let the weak say I am strong; Let the poor say I am rich.”***

Some folks think they can arbitrarily decide what to give. (Pastor who said, *“If you are not tithing, just start by tithing 2%”* A thief is a thief Bro!!!) In Malachi 3 the Word say’s if we do not tithe, we are **“robbing God”** - Or to put it another way, stealing from the Kingdom!

Be sure to know, the King doesn’t need our money – We need to give!

What if we do not return the tithe to the kingdom? We will ***“Be cursed with a curse.”*** No one can pray or pay us out from under a self-imposed curse! We can’t pray or pay our way out – We must obey our way out!!!

If we give ongoing help to people who are not tithing, we are not only enabling them, we are wasting our money and joining ourselves to the cause and effect of a cursed thief. We are literally throwing good money after bad money.

WHAT SHOULD THE EXPECTATION OF THE GENEROUS BE?

What happens when we begin tithing and doing generous things?

- The King will open the floodgates of Heaven...
- The King will pour out such a blessing that there will not be enough room to contain it...
- The King will prevent pests from destroying our increase... (Killer for hire) ***“Then all the nations will call you blessed, for yours will be a delightful land, says the Lord Almighty.”*** (Mal. 3: 8b-12).

Returning the tithe to the King and Kingdom, sets us up for Kingdom provision. A Kingdom investment is a “No lose” “Can’t miss” opportunity to invest in eternal things. Matthew 19:29-30 (NKJV) ***“Everyone who has left houses or brothers or sisters or father or mother or wife or children or lands, for My name’s sake, shall receive a hundredfold, and***

inherit eternal life. ³⁰ ***But many who are first will be last, and the last first.***” One translation say’s ***“Shall receive one hundred-fold in the here and now, and then inherit eternal life.”***

WHERE SHOULD I GIVE?

No farmer sows seed unless and until he knows what kind of soil, he is sowing it into! Giving is one thing, but to give to a King, is a completely different level altogether! When we give we should give to the King:

- Not the church...
- Not the ministry...
- Not the program...
- Not the person...

When we give to something, we become a part of it! When we give to a King, we become a part of all that His Kingdom entails.

Giving to a King activates the King’s obligation to demonstrate his glory and power to the giver.

When one gives to a King, that King automatically attempts to demonstrate to the giver that He is a greater King than all other Kings.

When we sow good seed into fertile soil, we get a good result. When we sow good seed into poor soil, we get a poor result!

When a citizen gives to a King, that citizen is acknowledging that all things belong to that King, and the citizen is grateful. When we give with the proper attitude, we can expect all the blessings made to tithers in the Word of God! When we give generously, we can expect generosity to flow in our direction from the King of the Kingdom. (Explain first-fruits)

The tithe belongs in the local church. The denomination that I have belonged to for the last 45 years requires its credential holders to pay 75% of their tithe to the District. I have never believed this to be a Biblical practice.

Over the past number of years, I have tithed to this church and given an equivalent of 75% of my tithe to the District. I found it necessary to live up to my commitment as a credential holder, but felt that I must contribute the tithe to my local church.

There is nothing wrong with giving to various causes outside our local church that we believe deserve a portion of our resources, but the tithe belongs in the local church. ***“Bring ALL the tithe into the storehouse...”***

CONCLUSION:

Something one is never to do, is to come before a King empty-handed. Often, we have come before the King to get what we have need of, and we do so empty-handed, offering nothing of worth. This should never be. We must NEVER come before our King with empty hands!

This is perfectly illustrated when the Queen of Sheba made an appearance before Solomon. 1

Kings 10:10 (NKJV) ***“And she gave the king 120 talents of gold, large quantities of spices, and precious stones. Never again were so many spices brought in as those the queen of Sheba gave to King Solomon.”*** We shouldn’t just bring a gift to the King we should bring the best and highest. (This is a real estate term)

King Solomon was greater in riches and wisdom than all the other kings of the earth, including the Queen of Sheba. The whole world sought audience with Solomon to hear the wisdom God had put in his heart. Year after year, everyone who came brought a gift: articles of silver and gold; expensive robes; weapons; spices; even horses and livestock. They brought the best they had!

Are we bringing the best we have?

Even though Solomon was richer than the Queen of Sheba, she still brought the best offering she could manage. I want to give where something is prosperous, not to keep something

afloat! I want to invest in something that is successful, not in something that is failing.

Coming before a King with a great, premeditated offering, is a thing of honor – To not do so is a thing of dishonor. (Leave your sick sacrifices outside – they are stinking the place up – David at the threshing floor of Araunah the Jebusite ***“I refuse to give to my God of that which cost me nothing.”***)

What do our gifts smell like today???